

Why Open-Source Developers Are Burning Out

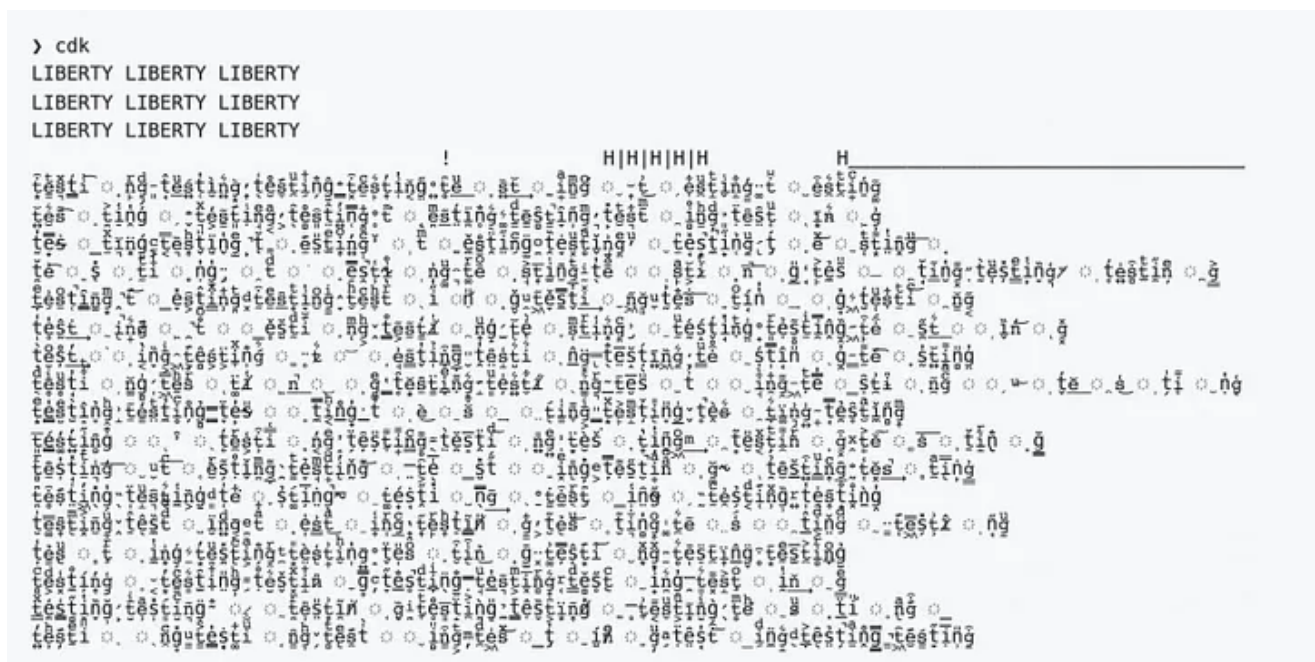
Open-source was supposed to be a barn-raising. It turned into unpaid labor by stressed-out individuals



Clive Thompson · [Follow](#)

Published in Better Programming

9 min read · Jan 13, 2022



There's a software library called "colors", which does one simple thing: It lets programmers change the color of text in Node apps.

It's quite popular; around 19,000 software projects currently use it, and it has over 20 million weekly downloads from people trying it out.

But recently, anyone using "colors" in their app got a shock when they updated that software library. Their screens all went haywire — producing the stream of nonsense text you see above.

What happened? Well, Marak Squires, the software developer for “colors”, had intentionally sabotaged his own library of code. He added an infinite loop that generated gibberish characters, utterly b0rking the functionality of “colors”.

And ... why would he do *that*? It's not fully clear; he may, as observers have noted, been having any number of mental-health issues.

But one thing Squires had recently made clear is that he was feeling burned out and economically exploited, because so many profitable companies were using his code, and not giving anything back. As he wrote in November 2020 ...

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Advice for programmers.

Written by Clive Thompson

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I write 2X a week on tech, science, culture — and how those collide. Writer at NYT mag/Wired; author, “Coders”. @clive@saturation.social clive@clivethompson.net

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What are your thoughts?



Jess Rohloff

Jan 22, 2022



Some random, vague ideas and thoughts.

It sounds like the open source developer community needs an additional support layer.

I'm not a developer, but I could contribute by fielding incoming emails and handling the human-interaction emotional... [more](#)



28



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Jess Rohloff

Jan 22, 2022



This really struck me. The best work I've ever done in my life was also unpaid. It was a community for tech and startup folks in New Orleans that I ran for 4 years. To this day it's the thing I'm most proud of and while I did kind of leverage it... [more](#)



13



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Bryant Biggs

Feb 15, 2022



If a developer burns out and walks away from their library (or torches it), that's their prerogative;

Actually, not true. As we saw with colorsjs, both NPM and GitHub forcefully took action to undo the authors sabotage. Is this good/bad - I don't know honestly. But two large entities stepped in to protect

their bottom line and the bottom lines of... [more](#)



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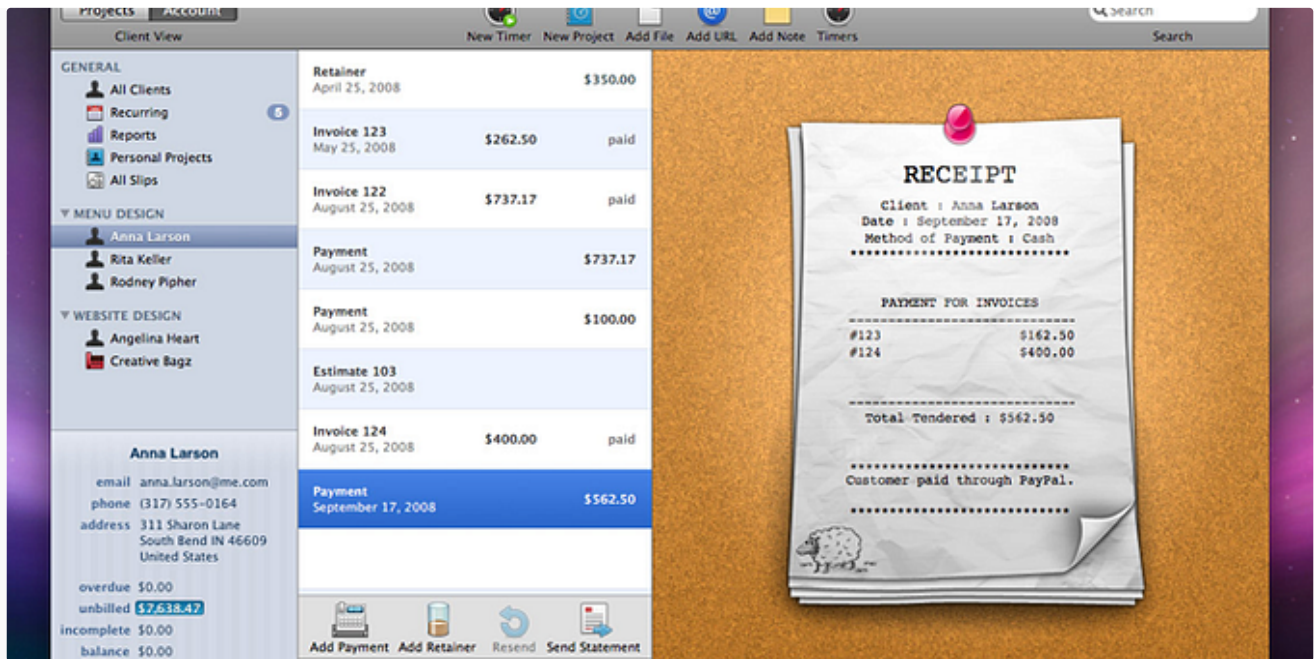
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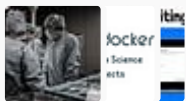
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@karpathy

There's a new kind of coding I call "vibe coding", where you fully give in to the vibes, embrace exponentials, and forget that the code even exists. It's possible because the LLMs (e.g. Cursor Composer w Sonnet) are getting too good. Also I just talk to Composer with SuperWhisper so I barely even touch the keyboard. I ask for the dumbest things like "decrease the padding on the sidebar by half" because I'm too lazy to find it. I "Accept All" always, I don't read the diffs anymore. When I get error messages I just copy paste them in with no comment, usually that fixes it. The code grows beyond my usual comprehension, I'd have to really read through it for a while. Sometimes the LLMs can't fix a bug so I just work around it or ask for random changes until it goes away. It's not



In CodeX by Austin Starks

I “vibe-coded” over 160,000 lines of code. It IS real.

When I was getting my MS from CMU and coding up the algorithmic trading platform NextTrade, I wrote every single goddamn line of code...



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